

Writing Three Thank-You Letters

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It was 1943, during World War II, and I was a young U.S. coast guardsman. My ship, the USS Murzim, had been under way for several days. Most of her holds contained thousands of **cartons**¹ of canned or dried foods. The other holds were **loaded** with five-hundred-pound bombs packed **delicately**(=carefully) in padded racks(装有棉垫的架子). Our destination was a big base on the island of Tulagi in the South Pacific.

1. Carton 表示纸板；旧时的水彩画都是画在较厚的纸板上，所以 carton 摇身一变，成了另一个新词“cartoon”，原先表示“纸板上的绘画”；后来语义范围逐渐缩小，变成“漫画”。

I was one of the Murzim's several cooks and, quite the same as for **folk**² ashore, this Thanksgiving morning had **seen**³ us busily preparing a traditional dinner **featuring**⁴ roast turkey.

2. Folk means people in general; a group of people;
3. See means to be the setting or time of (Merriam Webster); 所以原句也可以写成: This Thanksgiving morning had been a time of us busily preparing a traditional dinner.
4. Feature means to include sth as an important part; 所以原句可以理解成: The traditional dinner included roast turkey as its important part. 即这顿饭的主打菜是烤火鸡。

Well, as any cook knows, it's a lot of hard work to cook and serve a big meal, and clean up and put everything away. But finally, around **sundown**⁵, we finished at last.

I decided first to go out on the Murzim's afterdeck for a breath of open air. I made my way out there, breathing in great, deep **draughts**⁶ while walking slowly about, still wearing my white cook's hat.

5. Sundown has many synonyms, like twilight, dusk, sunset, nightfall.
6. Draught means a current of air, 气流; draught is the British English, and “draft” is the American English.

I got to thinking about Thanksgiving, of the Pilgrims, Indians, wild turkeys, pumpkins, corn on the cob, and the rest.

Yet my mind seemed to be **in quest of** something else -- some way that I could personally apply to **the close of**(=the end of) Thanksgiving. It must have taken me a half hour to sense that maybe some key to an answer could result from **reversing** the word "Thanksgiving" -- at least that **suggested**(=imply) a **verbal**(=related to word, 文字的) direction, "Giving thanks."

Giving thanks -- as in praying, thanking God, I thought. Yes, of course. Certainly.

Yet my mind continued turning the idea over.

After a while, like a **dawn**'s⁷ brightening, a further answer did come -- that there were people to thank, people who had done so much for me that I could never possibly repay them. The **embarrassing** truth was I'd always just accepted what they'd done, taken all of it for granted. Not one time had I ever **bothered**⁸ to express to any of them so much as⁹ a simple, sincere

"Thank you."

7. 前文我们有黄昏，此处是黎明，破晓。Dawn means sunrise, daybreak.

8. Bother to do means to take trouble to do sth. Take the trouble to do sth means to make an effort to do sth. 尝试做，尽力做。E.g. Thank you for taking the trouble to write us a reply. 感谢您的回复。

9. So much as simply means even. 所以原句理解为：I had never tried to express even a simple, sincere "Thank you" to any of them. 我从未主动向他们表达出我真诚的感激之情。

At least seven people had been particularly and lastingly helpful to me. I realized, swallowing hard, that about half of them had since died -- so they were forever beyond any possible expression of gratitude from me. The more I thought about it, the more ashamed I became. Then I pictured the three who were still alive and, within minutes, I was down in my cabin. Sitting at a table with writing paper and memories of things each had done, I tried composing (=writing) genuine(=sincere) statements of heartfelt appreciation and gratitude to my dad, Simon A. Haley, a professor at the old Agricultural Mechanical Normal College in Pine Bluff, Arkansas; to my grandma, Cynthia Palmer, back in our little hometown of Henning, Tennessee; and to the Rev. Lonual Nelson, my grammar school principal(校长), retired and living in Ripley, six miles north of Henning.

The texts of my letters began something like, "Here, this Thanksgiving at sea, I find my thoughts upon how much you have done for me, but I have never stopped and said to you how much I feel the need to thank you --" And briefly I recalled for each of them specific acts performed on my behalf.

For instance, something uppermost about my father was how he had impressed upon me from boyhood to love books and reading. In fact, this graduated(=change gradually) into a family habit of after-dinner quizzes at the table about books read most recently and new words learned. My love of books never diminished¹⁰ and later led me toward writing books myself. So many times I have felt a sadness when exposed to modern children so immersed¹¹ in the electronic media that they have little or no awareness of the marvelous world to be discovered in books.

10. Diminish means to progressively decline, like decrease, lessen, reduce.

11. Immerse means to engross or absorb. Johnsy was engrossed/immersed/absorbed in her fantasy.

I reminded¹² the Reverend Nelson how each morning he would open our little country town's grammar school with a prayer over his assembled students. I told him that whatever positive things I had done since had been influenced at least in part by his morning school prayers.

In the letter to my grandmother, I reminded her of a dozen ways she used to teach me how to tell the truth, to share, and to be forgiving and considerate of others. I thanked her for the years of eating her good cooking, the equal of which I had not found since¹³. Finally, I thanked her simply for having sprinkled¹⁴ my life with stardust.

12. Remind sb of sth. The noun form of remind is "reminder." E.g. This picture is a precious *reminder* of the happy past.

13. The underlined sentence structure can be changed to "I thanked her for her good cooking. I had not found a cooking that was as delicious as my grandmother's since I had left."

14. Sprinkle means to scatter 点缀

Before I slept, my three letters went into our ship's office mail sack. They got mailed when we reached Tulagi Island.

We unloaded cargo, reloaded with something else, then again we put to sea in the routine familiar to us, and as the days became weeks, my little personal experience receded¹⁵. Sometimes, when we were at sea, a mail ship would rendezvous and bring us mail from home, which, of course, we accorded¹⁶ topmost priority(=significance).

15. Recede means fade away, to grow less, diminish, decrease. 我们可以理解成 Those (exciting) personal experiences faded away as time went by. 以往的一些个人经历正在逐渐淡出脑海。

16. Accord means to give, grant. E.g. Every competitor, be he or her undergraduate or postgraduate, should be accorded equal respect. 每位竞争者, 无论是本科生还是研究生, 都应被给予尊重。

Every time the ship's loudspeaker rasped, "Attention! Mail call!" two hundred-odd shipmates came pounding up¹⁷ on deck and clustered about(=around) the two seamen, standing by those precious bulging(膨胀的) gray sacks. They were alternately pulling out fistfuls of letters and barking successive¹⁸ names of sailors who were, in turn, shouting back "Here! Here!" amid the pushing.

17. Pound means to move forcefully and heavily; up means in or into a state of greater intensity or excitement. 所以整个句子可以理解成: About 200 shipmates moved forcefully in a state of excitement on deck and surrounded the two seamen with reply letters.

18. 该词要学会应用。这个词是怎么来的呢? 我们看动词。

Succeed 有两层基本含义:

I. 成功, 由这层含义衍生出了 success(n.), successful(adj.), successfully.

II. 继承, 继任, 例如: He succeeds his father as the next language master. 他成为他父亲之后又一位语言大师。所以, 由这个含义衍生出了名词 succession, successive(延续的, 继任的, 一个接一个的), successively.

One "mail call" brought me responses from Grandma, Dad, and the Reverend Nelson -- and my reading of their letters left me not only astonished(amazed, startled) but more humbled than before.

Rather than saying they would forgive that I hadn't previously thanked them, instead, for Pete's sake, they were thanking me -- for having remembered, for having considered they had done anything so exceptional(=extraordinary, significantly different, outstanding).

Always the college professor, my dad had carefully avoided anything he considered too sentimental(sensitive, emotional), so I knew how moved he was to write me that, after having helped educate many young people, he now felt that his best results included his own son.

The Reverend Nelson wrote that his decades as a "simple, old-fashioned **principal**¹⁹" had ended with schools **undergoing**²⁰ such **swift**(=quick) changes that he had retired in self-doubt. "I heard more of what I had done wrong than what I did right," he said, adding that my letter had brought him welcome **reassurance**²¹ that his career had been appreciated.

19. 来做一个词形辨析

Principal vs Principle

Principal as a noun, means the leader, the dean of a school 表示校长; as an adjective, it means main, important, dominant 主要的, 重要的;

Principle is the moral rule you hold on to, 原则

20. Undergo means to endure, to go through.

21. Assure means to give confidence to; reassure means to restore confidence to, to cheer up, encourage.

A glance at Grandma's familiar handwriting brought back **in a flash** memories of standing alongside her white rocking chair, watching her "**settin' down**"²² some letter to relatives. Character by character, Grandma would **slowly accomplish one word, then the next, so that** a finished page would **consume** hours. I wept over the page representing my Grandma's recent hours invested in expressing her loving gratefulness to me -- whom she used to diaper!

22. 作者此处用 set down 而不用 write 的目的在于突出外婆写作的困难, set the words down, 这个表达似乎很愚钝、冗长和刻板, 恰恰突出外婆写作的困难。

Much later, retired from the Coast Guard and trying to make a living as a writer, I never forgot how those three "thank you" letters gave me an **insight**²³ into how most human beings go about **longing** in secret **for**²⁴ more of their fellows to express appreciation for their efforts.

Now, approaching another Thanksgiving, I have asked myself what will I wish for all who are reading this, for our nation, indeed for our whole world -- since, quoting a good and wise friend of mine, "In the end we are **mightily** and merely people, each with similar needs." First, I wish for us, of course, the simple common sense to achieve world peace, that being **paramount**(=important) for the very survival of our kind.

23. Insight means: the power of seeing into a situation.

24. Long means to have a strong desire or to crave especially for something not likely to be attained.

And there is something else I wish -- so strongly that I have had this line printed across the bottom of all my **stationery**²⁵: "Find the good -- and praise it."

25. 同学们还是需要注意几个词的词形辨析:

I. Station, 表示公交站, 火车站; 既然是站点, 某一站, 那么一定是固定的位置, 所以该词的形容词 **stationary** 表示 fixed, immobile, unchanging, 稳定的, 固定不变的;

II. 而 **stationery** 表示学习用品, 文具; 信笺;

III. 此外, 我们还有两个词, 同学们要注意区分, 一个是 vocation, 表示职业, 即 occupation; 一个是 vacation, 表示假期, 即 holiday, a period spent away from home and work.